The Emptying — Phase 2 Systems (Colony Sim)

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Every system the colony sim needs, what it does, what it connects to and why. Status marks each as carried over from the earlier design, changed, or new. Details belong to Phase 3.

The relic and rule

These are the player's levers: the relic's influence, the ruler it controls, and the laws and beliefs that decide whether people obey.

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
Relic influence	Abstract power that grows with relics, fragments and sacrifices; raises obedience	Obedience, ring, escalation	The player is the relic	New
Ruler and succession	A visible king or queen under the relic; on death, pick 1 of 3 successors	Influence, events, laws	Tropico-style face of the crown	New
Beliefs and public opinion	What each person thinks about topics (cults, vampires, slavery, war)	Campaigns, obedience, blocs, religion	Laws only work if people accept them	New
Campaigns	Spend gold and a speaker over 10 to 30 days to shift a belief	Beliefs, lords, priests, gold	Soft power instead of orders	New

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
Obedience	Whether people follow a given law, from belief plus influence	Laws, crime, beliefs, influence	Any law can be set; not every law is followed	New
Laws and rules	Rules manage the kingdom; laws affect people	Obedience, crime, economy, religion	Your main way to shape society	Changed
Crime and justice	Crimes, detection, trials, punishment, jail, the warden	Laws, obedience, morality	Disobedience and crime need consequences	Carried over
The ring and fragments	The relic's area of control; fragments (found, made, traded) start new rings	Settlements, influence, people's movement	Where you can rule and settle	New
The being's escalation	Four stages from Quiet to Waking as relics and influence grow	Relics, events, cults	Long-term pull for an endless sandbox	New
Relics	Found relics with research trees and strange or dark demands	Influence, research, escalation	Power with a cost	Changed

People and colony life

The colonist simulation carries over almost whole; what changes is that people now decide everything for themselves within the permissions you give.

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
Colonist simulation	Needs, moods, thoughts, mental breaks, schedules	Everything	Living people	Carried over
Work permissions	Oxygen Not Included-style boxes for which work each person may do	Jobs, skills, building AI	Replaces direct orders	New
Jobs and skills	Skills 0 to 20; building worker limits; the best take the role	Permissions, economy, buildings	Who does what, by merit	Changed
Preferences and traits	Food, home area, job, room, company, faith	Mood, races, immigration	Distinct people	Carried over
Relationships and blocs	Opinions, romance, rivalries, blocs with demands	Beliefs, laws, morality	A society, not a crowd	Carried over
Morality	Each person's moral stance and reaction to acts	Laws, obedience, beliefs	Dark choices cost people	Carried over
Races	Race needs, attitudes, reproduction, and environmental weaknesses (sun, cold, holy ground)	Map regions, immigration, unlocks	Every race plays differently	Changed
Life cycle	Children, aging (humans), old age, death, grief, graveyards	Relationships, property	People live whole lives	Carried over
Health, injury and trauma	Injury tiers, disease, plague, trauma after violence	Combat, medicine, events	Violence and hardship leave marks	Carried over

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
Immigration	Arrivals, vetting rules, single immigrants only	Ring, location, beliefs	How the colony grows	Carried over
Religion	Seven faiths, worship buildings, conversion, cults	Beliefs, blocs, escalation	Faith shapes society	Carried over
Captives and slavery	Prisoners, slaves, torture, slave drivers, the market	Laws, morality, economy	A dark path that's always open	Carried over

Building, settlements and economy

The biggest new piece is the town-growth AI: people deciding what to build and where, inside your zones and incentives.

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
Town-growth AI	People notice needs (wood, food, tools) and build homes, shops and production themselves	Zones, incentives, economy, property	Colonists build their own town	New
Crown building	You place government works: defenses, government housing, prison, hospital, research, warehouses, roads, the keep	Wages, defense, research	The few things you build directly	Changed

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
Zones	Residential (low, middle, high), commercial, industrial, farm	Town-growth AI, land tax	Where growth may happen	Carried over
Property and land ownership	Who owns which plot, home or business; selling, inheriting	Life cycle, wealth, taxes	First settlers become landowners	New
Incentives	Grants, tax breaks, crown requests with rewards, government wages	Town-growth AI, economy	Steering without orders	New
Economy and resources	Raw, processed and finished goods, chains of 3, spoilage, meals, blood, suffering, demonic energy	Everything productive	What the colony runs on	Carried over
Wages, wealth and businesses	Personal money, stipends, private businesses, need-based openings, bankruptcy	Town-growth AI, taxes, homes	People work for gold	Carried over
Taxes and corruption	Wage and land taxes, skimming lords, auditors	Economy, lords	Revenue and its leaks	Carried over
Settlements	Extra towns inside fragment rings, sharing your laws	Ring, fragments, location	Mining towns and outposts	Changed

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
Research	Tabs (kingdom, military, society, medicine, race, relic); context-based trees; production-based research	Relics, crown building, races	Long-term progress	Changed
Trade	Trade with off-map kingdoms and on-map groups, including slaves	Off-map layer, economy	Goods you can't make	Changed

World, lords and the off-map layer

A fixed map populated at random, small groups that grow beside you, and a menu-based world beyond the map edge.

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
World generation	Rolls groups, sites, kingdoms, people and religions from set variables once the keep is placed	Map, keep placement, off-map layer	Every game is different on a known map	New
Map regions and placement effects	Regions with traits (magic forest, ruins, mountains) that change threats, immigrants and resources	Generation, races, events	Where you start matters	New

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
On-map groups	Cults, bandits, creature dens and others: 1 to 3 people with goals, growing into small settlements	Diplomacy, threats, beliefs	Neighbors that grow with you	New
Wildlife	Animals, hunting and animal attacks	Regions, food, events	A living map	New
Off-map kingdoms	Random kingdoms on a menu map: trade, attacks, envoys	Trade, diplomacy, threats	The wider world without simulating it	Changed
Diplomacy	Standing with on-map groups and off-map kingdoms	Trade, threats, missions	Relations beyond the colony	Changed
Lords	Emerge as the kingdom grows; can be forced; jobs, traits, temperament, loyalty	Missions, governance, corruption	Leaders with their own minds	Changed
Off-map missions	Menu missions led by lords, or by regular people at lower returns and higher risk	Lords, off-map layer, injuries	What happens beyond the map	Changed
Spies	Agents in other kingdoms; enemy spies arriving as immigrants	Off-map layer, immigration	Intelligence and its risks	Carried over
Events and storyteller	Random and scripted events, event chains, tuned by difficulty and escalation	Everything	Stories emerge	Carried over

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
Time and weather	Clock, pause, speed, day and night, seasons, weather	Race weaknesses, farming, events	The world moves	Carried over

Defense and combat

Fights happen on the map with no direct control: you raise the alarm and set the policies, and fighters act on them by personality.

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
Alarm and muster flags	Sounding the alarm sends able fighters to flags you place	Military, civilians, shelters	Defense without orders	New
Military policies	Defend zones, patrol routes, engage rules, fall-back health	Combat AI, personalities	How soldiers act on their own	New
Combat AI	Soldiers choose targets and tactics by policy and personality (brave charge, cowards hang back)	Policies, morale, traits	Fights without a player hand	New
Combat rules	Damage, counters, armor and weight, morale, after-battle survival math, medics, trauma	Health, equipment	One set of rules for every fight	Carried over
Standing military	Soldiers leave civilian jobs, eat more, train, earn soldier wages, serve set terms; draft law	Economy, laws, barracks	A real cost to keeping an army	Carried over

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
Equipment	Master buildings, loadouts by class, auto-picking the best armor available, gear owned until lost	Smiths, economy, military	Production matters in war	Carried over
Defenses	Walls, gates, towers (wood, stone, reinforced), staffed through government wages	Crown building, wages	Turtling is a valid way to play	Changed
Civilian safety	Shelters, alarm bells, civilians fleeing attacks	Alarm, crown building	Raids threaten everyone	Carried over

Meta, setup and technical

The shell around each game, plus the technical systems that make 500 autonomous people possible.

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
Game setup	Name the kingdom, choose a race and stats, place the keep; start with 3 random people	Generation, races	Every game begins here	New
Race unlocks	Main-menu screen of races earned by meeting and allying with them; kept across games	Diplomacy, races	Long-term progression	New
Tutorial	A dedicated small tutorial	Core systems	Teaching a deep game	Changed

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
Difficulty and settings	Easy, normal and hard presets, every setting tweakable; ironman	Events, threats, economy	Players tune their game	Changed
Simulation performance	Keeping 500 deep-simulation people running smoothly, such as people far from the camera thinking less often	Every simulated system	Required by the target population	New
Pathfinding and traffic	Movement for hundreds of people across a large map	Town-growth AI, combat	Crowds have to move	Carried over
Saves	Manual saves, rotating autosaves, ironman, version safety, local only	Everything	Required	Carried over
Game data	All content as data, spreadsheet intake, validation, permanent IDs, separate text files, mod support	Every content system	Easy to add and change content	Carried over
UI	Main screens, overlays, alerts, tooltips, sortable people list, the advisor's forecasts; new screens for beliefs, influence and the ring	Every system	Managing it all	Changed
Camera and controls	Tilted top-down camera; no unit commands; permission boxes, zones, flags and menus	UI	Playing without touching people	Changed

System	What it does	Connects to	Why the game needs it	Status
Audio	Dynamic music darkening with escalation, a living soundscape, voice later	Escalation, events	Mood and feedback	Carried over

Dropped, overlaps, conflicts and gaps

Several earlier systems no longer fit, three pairs overlap, and a few pieces of the earlier design need a decision before Phase 3.

Dropped

- The hero, hero perks and the hero's productivity effects
- RTS battles, battle economy and setups, claimed keeps as separate maps
- Story acts, the midpoint sacrifice, the final war and the Emptying as an ending
- Overworld travel as a costed trip (missions are now menu-based)

Overlaps, resolved

- **Morality, beliefs and opinion of the ruler:** kept as three separate values, with more inputs added: environment, time of day and weather. The goal is for people to think like real humans.
- **Laws, obedience and enforcement:** law options appear as situations first happen. Example: the first time someone is caught stealing, you choose what to do, and that becomes a rule you can set (a fine, or execution if you're hardcore). Enforcement rules are adjustable. Government employees are more loyal because you pay them.
- **One director** runs both random events and the being's escalation stages.

Earlier pieces, decided

- **The relic's voice:** dropped from this game. It's lore, kept for a future RTS game; the shared story can support about three games.

- **Alignment and the embassy:** not used with off-map kingdoms. Groups on the map have three simple standings: hated (they may attack), neutral (they don't attack) and liked (they may ask to trade). The never-equal rule is dropped.
- **Generals:** remain a lord's job. Generals command at muster flags, boost nearby soldiers and lead off-map missions.
- **Outposts:** the same system as fragment settlements, at two sizes: a small one (a mine or a farm) is an outpost, a larger one is a town.

Gaps

Added as full systems:

- Fire and disasters
- Inheritance of property and wealth
- Light and darkness (sunlight for vampires, darkness for crime)